**SCADAIntel**

Pricing

# SCADA Consultant Rate Guide 2026

Real pricing data — hourly rates, assessment costs, and engagement models for ICS/SCADA cybersecurity consulting

- Hourly and daily rates by consultant tier and specialization
- Project-based pricing for assessments, pen tests, and compliance audits
- Hidden fees to watch for (travel, tooling, remediation scope creep)
- How to negotiate better rates with firms and independents

# How SCADA/ICS Security Consulting Billing Works

SCADA and ICS cybersecurity consulting operates at the premium end of the security market. These are not generic IT security engagements — they require specialized knowledge of industrial protocols (Modbus, DNP3, OPC UA, EtherNet/IP), safety-instrumented systems, and the operational reality that you cannot "reboot the plant." Understanding the billing structure helps you budget accurately and avoid surprise costs.

## Billing Structure Overview

| Component | Description | Typical Range |
|---|---|---|
| Initial scoping / discovery | Site survey, asset inventory, threat model scoping | $5,000–$25,000 |
| Security assessment (per facility) | Vulnerability assessment, network architecture review, policy gap analysis | $25,000–$150,000 |
| Penetration testing (ICS-specific) | Active testing of SCADA/ICS systems in controlled conditions | $30,000–$200,000+ |
| Compliance audit (NERC CIP, IEC 62443) | Gap analysis against specific regulatory framework | $20,000–$100,000 |
| Remediation consulting | Implementing fixes, segmentation, monitoring deployment | $150–$400/hr or project-based |
| Retainer / ongoing advisory | Continuous monitoring, incident response readiness, quarterly reviews | $5,000–$25,000/ month |

**Quick Budget Reference**

- Single-facility OT vulnerability assessment: $25,000–$75,000
- Multi-site ICS security assessment (3-5 facilities): $100,000–$400,000
- NERC CIP compliance gap analysis + remediation plan: $50,000–$200,000
- ICS penetration test (controlled, non-disruptive): $30,000–$150,000
- Annual OT security retainer (advisory + incident response): $60,000–$300,000/year

# Consultant Hourly and Daily Rates by Tier

## ICS/SCADA Security Consultant Rate Tiers — Your Benchmark

SCADA/ICS cybersecurity is one of the most specialized — and expensive — consulting niches. The talent pool is small (ICS security professionals represent <1% of the cybersecurity workforce), and the consequences of hiring unqualified consultants in this space include operational disruption, safety incidents, and regulatory penalties. Premium rates reflect premium risk.

| Consultant Tier | Hourly Rate | Daily Rate | Typical Role | Key Certifications |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Junior OT Security Analyst | $150–$250/hr | $1,200–$2,000/day | Asset inventory, network mapping, log analysis | Security+, CySA+, GICSP (in progress) |
| Mid-Level ICS Security Consultant | $250–$400/hr | $2,000–$3,200/day | Vulnerability assessment, architecture review, policy development | GICSP, GRID, ISA/IEC 62443 Cybersecurity Certificate |
| Senior ICS/SCADA Specialist | $350–$500/hr | $2,800–$4,000/day | Pen testing, incident response, compliance leadership | GICSP, GRID, GCIP, CISSP + OT specialization |
| Principal / Practice Lead | $450–$650/hr | $3,600–$5,200/day | Strategic advisory, CISO-level consulting, program architecture | GICSP, GRID, CISSP, ISA/IEC 62443 Expert |
| Elite / Incident Commander | $500–$1,200/hr | $4,000–$9,600/day | Nation-state threat response, critical infrastructure crisis, expert testimony | GICSP, GRID, GCIP, CISSP, former government/military |

## Firm vs. Independent Rates

| Engagement Model | Rate Range | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Global firms (Dragos, Claroty, Nozomi professional services) | $350–$650/hr | Deep tooling, threat intelligence, vendor relationships |
| Specialized ICS boutiques (Red Trident, GRIMM, Verve) | $250–$500/hr | Focused OT expertise, smaller teams, hands-on principals |

| Engagement Model | Rate Range | Notes |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Regional / niche consultancies | $200–$400/hr | Local knowledge, compliance-focused |
| Independent consultants | $150–$350/hr | Lowest cost, specialized expertise, single point of failure |

*Sources: SANS ICS salary surveys, cybersecurity consulting rate benchmarks, industry analyst reports 2025-2026.*

**Key Rule of Thumb**

The cheapest SCADA security consultant is almost never the best value. An unqualified assessor who misses a critical vulnerability in your ICS environment creates risk that dwarfs the rate differential. In OT security, mistakes have physical consequences — budget for quality.

# Assessment Pricing by Type

| Assessment Type | Typical Cost | Duration | Deliverable |
|---|---|---|---|
| OT Asset Discovery & Inventory | $10,000–$30,000 | 1-2 weeks | Complete asset map with make/model/firmware/network position |
| Passive Network Assessment | $20,000–$60,000 | 2-4 weeks | Network architecture diagram, traffic analysis, anomaly findings |
| Active Vulnerability Assessment | $30,000–$100,000 | 2-6 weeks | Vulnerability report with CVSS scores, remediation priorities |
| ICS Penetration Test | $50,000–$200,000+ | 3-8 weeks | Exploitation report, attack paths, proof-of-concept findings |
| Architecture Review (IEC 62443) | $25,000–$75,000 | 2-4 weeks | Zone/conduit model, SL assessment, gap analysis |
| NERC CIP Compliance Audit | $30,000–$150,000 | 4-12 weeks | Standards-mapped findings, evidence gaps, remediation roadmap |
| NIST 800-82 Gap Analysis | $20,000–$80,000 | 2-6 weeks | Control-by-control gap assessment, prioritized action plan |
| Tabletop Exercise (ICS-specific) | $10,000–$30,000 | 1-3 days | Scenario documentation, response evaluation, improvement plan |
| Full ICS Security Program Build | $100,000–$500,000+ | 3-12 months | Policies, procedures, technology, training, governance framework |

**Passive vs. Active — Know the Difference**

Passive assessments monitor network traffic without touching systems — safe for production environments. Active assessments interact with devices (scan, probe, test) and carry operational risk. Never allow active testing on production ICS systems without a maintenance window, rollback plan, and safety review.

# Pricing by Industry Sector

## Rate Variations by Industry — What Drives the Premium

| Industry Sector | Assessment Cost Range | Key Cost Drivers | Compliance Framework |
|---|---|---|---|
| Electric Utilities (Generation + T&D) | $75,000–$400,000 | NERC CIP mandatory compliance, BES Cyber System complexity | NERC CIP v5/v7 |
| Oil & Gas (Upstream + Midstream) | $50,000–$300,000 | Remote sites, hazardous environments, safety-instrumented systems | IEC 62443, API 1164 |
| Water / Wastewater | $25,000–$150,000 | Budget-constrained, aging infrastructure, EPA requirements | AWIA 2018, NIST 800-82 |
| Manufacturing (Discrete + Process) | $30,000–$200,000 | Production uptime requirements, IT/OT convergence complexity | IEC 62443, NIST CSF |
| Chemical / Pharmaceutical | $50,000–$250,000 | Safety-instrumented systems, EPA/OSHA requirements | IEC 62443, CFATS |
| Transportation / Pipeline | $40,000–$200,000 | TSA Security Directives, geographic distribution | TSA SD Pipeline-2021-02 |
| Building Automation (BAS) | $15,000–$75,000 | Lower risk profile, less complex OT environment | NIST 800-82, local codes |

**Regulatory Multiplier**

NERC CIP-regulated utilities pay 2-3x more for compliance-specific assessments because the consultant must document findings to CIP evidence standards, not just identify vulnerabilities. If you're NERC CIP-registered, budget accordingly.

# Hidden Fees & Add-Ons

Always get a detailed SOW with fixed-fee milestones. SCADA security engagements are notorious for scope expansion — every assessment uncovers issues that create additional remediation work. Budget 30-50% contingency above the quoted assessment fee.

| Add-On | Typical Cost | When You Need It |
|---|---|---|
| Travel to facility (per trip) | $2,000–$8,000 | Every on-site engagement — OT assessments cannot be done fully remote |
| Specialized tooling licenses | $5,000–$20,000 | ICS-specific scanning tools (Nessus OT, Tenable.ot, Claroty licenses) |
| Safety review / MOC (Management of Change) | $5,000–$15,000 | Required before any active testing in SIS-protected environments |
| Remediation consulting (post-assessment) | $150–$400/hr | Implementing fixes identified in the assessment |
| Network segmentation design | $25,000–$100,000 | Most common remediation — separating IT and OT networks |
| Monitoring solution deployment | $50,000–$250,000 | Deploying OT-specific monitoring (Dragos, Claroty, Nozomi) |
| Incident response retainer | $5,000–$25,000/month | Pre-negotiated IR availability (2-4 hour response SLA) |
| Training / awareness workshops | $5,000–$15,000/session | OT-specific cybersecurity training for operators and engineers |
| Re-assessment (annual) | 50-70% of initial assessment | Verifying remediation effectiveness and detecting new vulnerabilities |
| Expert witness / regulatory testimony | $500–$1,200/hr | If assessment findings lead to regulatory proceedings |
| Report customization (board-level) | $3,000–$10,000 | Executive summary and risk quantification for board presentation |

Negotiate travel expenses upfront: specify per-trip caps, economy travel, and government per diem rates. For multi-site engagements, cluster site visits geographically to minimize travel costs. A 5-facility assessment with poor scheduling can add $30,000+ in unnecessary travel.

# How to Negotiate Better Rates

## Numbered list

1. **Bundle assessment + remediation.** Consultants who identify problems and fix them in one engagement are 15-25% cheaper than hiring separate firms for assessment and remediation. The assessment firm already understands your environment.

2. **Negotiate multi-year retainers.** Annual reassessments are cheaper than one-off engagements (50-70% of initial cost). A 3-year retainer with annual assessments locks in rates and builds institutional knowledge.

3. **Combine compliance frameworks.** If you need both NERC CIP and IEC 62443 assessments, negotiate a combined engagement. The overlap is significant — paying for two separate assessments is paying for redundant work.

4. **Use passive assessment as a first step.** If budget is tight, start with a passive network assessment ($20,000-$60,000) before committing to a full active assessment ($50,000-$200,000). Passive findings often reveal the most critical issues.

5. **Leverage vendor-neutral consultants.** Consultants affiliated with OT monitoring vendors (Dragos, Claroty, Nozomi) may steer you toward their platform. Vendor-neutral assessors give unbiased recommendations — then you can competitively bid the monitoring solution.

6. **Time engagements outside peak season.** Utility compliance deadlines (NERC CIP audit cycles) drive peak demand in Q2 and Q4. Q1 and Q3 are quieter — consultants are more negotiable.

7. **Define scope precisely in the SOW.** Vague scope like "assess our SCADA security" guarantees scope creep. Specify: which facilities, which systems, which protocols, which compliance framework, and what's excluded.

8. **Get three quotes.** Even in this specialized market, rate variation between firms for comparable scope can be 30-50%. Always compare at least 3 proposals.

9. **Negotiate knowledge transfer.** Include a requirement for the consultant to train your internal OT security staff during the engagement. This reduces your dependency on external consultants for ongoing work.

10. **Ask about government-funded programs.** CISA offers free ICS security assessments for critical infrastructure operators. Water utilities can access EPA/AWWA cybersecurity resources. Check eligibility before spending on commercial assessments.

# Budget Planning Worksheet

**Use this worksheet to estimate total ICS/SCADA security consulting costs. Print and fill in for each engagement.**

| Line Item | Estimated Cost | Actual Cost |
|---|---|---|
| Initial scoping / discovery | $____________ | $____________ |
| OT asset discovery and inventory | $____________ | $____________ |
| Vulnerability assessment | $____________ | $____________ |
| Penetration testing (if applicable) | $____________ | $____________ |
| Compliance gap analysis (framework: _______) | $____________ | $____________ |
| Network segmentation design | $____________ | $____________ |
| Remediation consulting labor | $____________ | $____________ |
| Monitoring solution (hardware + licensing) | $____________ | $____________ |
| Training / awareness workshops | $____________ | $____________ |
| Specialized tooling licenses | $____________ | $____________ |
| Travel expenses (x trips, x sites) | $____________ | $____________ |
| Report customization (board / regulatory) | $____________ | $____________ |
| **40% contingency buffer** | $____________ | $____________ |
| **TOTAL ESTIMATED** | $____________ | $____________ |

> Complete this worksheet before requesting proposals. Knowing your full scope — number of facilities, asset count, compliance requirements, and remediation appetite — helps consultants give accurate fixed-fee proposals and prevents costly scope expansion.

## CTA box

Need a reality check on your OT security budget? Email this worksheet to contact@scadaintel.com or browse vetted SCADA consultants at scadaintel.com

SCADAIntel

# SCADAIntel

Hire SCADA consultants you can vet.

**Browse consultants at scadaintel.com**

scadaintel.com | contact@scadaintel.com